

Recommendation Rabbit Hole Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Technology • 30-40 min

Category	Knowledge and Technology	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	recommendation-rabbit-hole

Big idea: A feed can become a path dependency: early clicks shape later knowledge possibilities.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Starting interest: exam stress; feed branches into study tips, productivity hacks, anxiety posts, tutoring adverts, and sleep science. Rank, sort, or audit this output. Identify which rule, ranking signal, or interface choice shaped your judgement.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Starting interest: climate action; feed branches into science explainers, activism, conspiracy claims, policy debate, and lifestyle content. Rank, sort, or audit this output. Identify which rule, ranking signal, or interface choice shaped your judgement.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Recommendation Rabbit Hole Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Starting interest: climate action; feed branches into science explainers, activism, conspiracy claims, policy debate, and lifestyle content. Rank, sort, or audit this output. Identify which rule, ranking signal, or interface choice shaped your judgement.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — A feed can become a path dependency: early clicks shape later knowledge possibilities.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Recommendation Rabbit Hole Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	When does personalization become distortion?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Starting interest: exam stress; feed branches into study tips, productivity hacks, anxiety posts, tutoring adverts, and sleep science.
- Starting interest: climate action; feed branches into science explainers, activism, conspiracy claims, policy debate, and lifestyle content.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Technology.

Activity Steps

1. Give each student or group a starting interest card.
2. Students choose one item from a small feed of mixed content.
3. The algorithm adds more cards similar to the chosen card in the next round.
4. Repeat for three or four rounds and map how feeds diverge.
5. Debrief what users might come to believe is normal, popular, or true.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: When does personalization become distortion?
- Is a recommendation a neutral convenience or an argument about relevance?
- Who is responsible for the knowledge environment created by a feed?

Knowledge Questions

- When does personalization become distortion?
- How do technological systems shape what knowers notice?
- Can visibility be mistaken for importance?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a chain of recommended videos or posts simulated with paper cards. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...